

Observer Effect Roleplay Teacher Notes

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Human Sciences • 30-40 min

Category	Human Sciences	Time	30-40 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	observer-effect-roleplay

Big idea: In human sciences, observation can become part of the situation being observed.

Overview

Students roleplay a classroom observation study and examine how being observed changes behavior and evidence.

Student Prompt

Inspect Observer Effect Roleplay Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Observer Effect Roleplay Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: Task: build the tallest paper tower in five minutes while observers visibly tally leadership, interruptions, and suggestions. Predict how people will respond, then identify the wording, context, incentive, or role that could change the result.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Observer Effect Roleplay Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Second round: observers sit farther away and use a simpler tally scheme. Predict how people will respond, then identify the wording, context, incentive, or role that could change the result.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Observer Effect Roleplay Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: Second round: observers sit farther away and use a simpler tally scheme. Predict how people will respond, then identify the wording, context, incentive, or role that could change the result.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — In human sciences, observation can become part of the situation being observed.

Actual Lesson Questions and Key

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Observer Effect Roleplay Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Observer Effect Roleplay Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
6	Can observation alter what is known?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how in human sciences, observation can become part of the situation being observed.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Setup Checklist

- Make the observation visible and ethical; students should know the activity studies observation effects.
- Use a harmless group task where behavior can naturally vary.

Ready-to-Use Examples

- Task: build the tallest paper tower in five minutes while observers visibly tally leadership, interruptions, and suggestions.
- Second round: observers sit farther away and use a simpler tally scheme.

Suggested Timing

Stage	Teacher move	Watch for
1	Assign some students to perform a simple group task and others to observe.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
2	Run one round with obvious observation and one with a less intrusive method.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
3	Observers tally behavior using a fixed coding scheme.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
4	Participants reflect on whether observation changed how they acted.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
5	Debrief validity, ethics, and method choice.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
Debrief	Move from the activity result to a TOK knowledge question.	Students distinguishing method, evidence, interpretation, and overclaiming.

Teacher Language

- In human sciences, the method can enter the behavior it measures.
- Which version gave cleaner data, and which version was more natural?

Common Misconceptions

- Students may treat class behaviour as universal human nature.
- Students may ignore ethical limits or context effects in human-subject inquiry.

Assessment Look-Fors

- Connects behaviour to method, context, incentives, and ethical constraints.
- Avoids overgeneralising from one small sample.

Differentiation and Adaptations

- Support: use two coded behaviors.
- Challenge: compare observer agreement between two coders.

Extension Tasks

- Students redesign the observation to improve validity while preserving consent.
- Connect to classroom observations, workplace studies, and ethnography.

Related Activities

- Conformity without Humiliation
- Survey Wording Experiment
- Observation is Theory-Laden